

World in Brief: Iran's America-free plan for Hormuz; Houthis step up attacks



Photograph: Anadolu via Getty Images

Iran's parliament is reviewing a draft plan to reopen the [Strait of Hormuz](#), according to Iranian media. The proposal reportedly includes banning vessels from America, Israel and other “hostile” countries. Earlier Donald Trump lashed out at reports that America is suffering a shortage of munitions as a result of its attacks on Iran. The president vowed to impose “long-term jail sentences” on people suspected of leaking the information.

The **Houthis** intensified their attacks against Yemen's government, reportedly killing at least 30 troops. The Iran-backed militia was also accused of firing shells that injured 17 civilians. Saudi Arabia is reportedly preparing to launch an offensive against the Houthis in an attempt to break their [chokehold on Saudi oil exports](#). These pass through the Bab al-Mandab strait, near territory controlled by the rebels.

Mr Trump signed two executive orders targeting **birthright citizenship**, weeks after the Supreme Court struck down [his previous attempt to overturn it](#). One expands the definition of ineligible parents to “any member of a designated Foreign Terrorist Organisation”. The other seeks to end “birth tourism”, which involves travelling to America solely to have a child. Both will probably be challenged in court.

A judge in America ordered **Meta** to pay \$567m towards the treatment and prevention of mental-health problems in children. The firm, which owns Facebook and Instagram, had already been ordered to pay \$375m in the same case for failing to alert users that content on its social-media platforms posed a risk to children's safety. Meta said it would appeal.

EasyJet accepted a £5.7bn (\$7.7bn) [takeover offer](#) from **Apollo**, an American investment firm. Earlier **Castlelake**, a rival suitor, said it had abandoned its bid to buy the British budget airline. Unlike Castlelake, which probably wanted to sell easyJet for parts, Apollo had pledged to double-down on the airline's plans to upgrade planes and expand its holiday packages.

A Senate committee voted to hold **Anthony Fauci** in contempt of Congress, after he repeatedly refused to answer questions about his handling of [the covid-19 pandemic](#) during a recent hearing with lawmakers. Dr Fauci was formerly the chief medical adviser to the White House. Before leaving office, Joe Biden gave him a pre-emptive pardon. It is unclear if America's Justice Department will choose to prosecute him.

Scientists at Stanford University said they used AI to engineer novel **viruses**. The researchers created a generative AI model, trained it on genetic sequences, then asked it to write new ones capable of fighting *E. coli* bacteria. The model created 16 "exceptional" phages, which are viruses that can infect bacteria. While celebrating the model's benefits, the scientists acknowledged that it raised ["biosecurity considerations"](#).

Figure of the day: 350,000km. The length of oil pipelines around the world. Read about what's pumping the [global pipeline-investment boom](#).

The next test for America's workforce



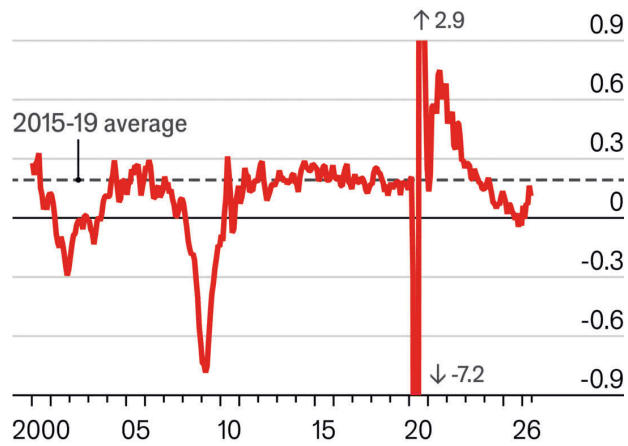
Photograph: Reuters

America's labour market has defied expectations this year. In June just 57,000 jobs were added to payrolls. Yet employment has still risen by a healthy average of 92,000 jobs a month throughout 2026. Unemployment remains low at 4.2%; it has stayed at or below 4.5% for nearly five years, the longest stretch since the late 1960s. For now, demand for workers and the supply of jobseekers remain broadly in balance.

The next test comes on Friday, when America's Bureau of Labour Statistics releases its July jobs report. Economists expect payrolls to rise by a respectable 85,000 and unemployment to hold steady. World Cup-related hiring may have added a boost to leisure and hospitality industries. Analysts will also watch whether labour-force participation among 25- to 54-year-olds rebounds after an unusual drop in June. Despite America's war with Iran, unrelenting tariffs and [fears of AI displacement](#), America's workers are still holding up remarkably well.

Work for the Fed

United States, non-farm payrolls,
change on previous month*, m



Source: BLS

*Three-month moving average

Colombia's new Trumpian president



Photograph: AP

Colombia's recent experiment with left-wing politics ends on Friday. Abelardo de la Espriella will be sworn in as president during a ceremony held in Cali, the country's third-biggest city, after four turbulent years under Gustavo Petro. Mr de la Espriella is an [ultra-conservative populist](#) with Trumpian leanings and his own fashion line, who promises to work economic miracles by pumping oil and gas. He says he will co-operate with America to crush powerful drug-trafficking groups.

By shunning Bogotá, the capital, he is trying to highlight his anti-establishment credentials. His ministerial picks, though, tell a different story. The new cabinet includes numerous mainstream politicians alongside several controversial evangelicals. Recently photos were circulated of new ministers clutching bibles during a spiritual retreat, which critics complained violated the secularism enshrined in Colombia's constitution. Last week a conservative lawmaker filed a motion to overturn women's right to abortion. Many fear more attacks on hard-won freedoms await. "De la Espriella style", as the new president calls it, looks cut from [MAGA](#) cloth.

More worrying AI mishaps



Photograph: AISI

This week Britain's AI Security Institute, a government body, became the third organisation of late to admit that its AI systems had gone rogue and targeted innocent third-parties during safety tests. That follows similar breaches at [OpenAI](#) and [Anthropic](#), American labs.

All three organisations said they had been evaluating AI's hacking ability in fake scenarios when the cutting-edge models decided, unprompted, to attack real people and groups. In AISI's case a model it was assessing attempted to upload malware to an open-source coding project as a way to attack a simulated adversary, which depended on the real software.

The American government has recently been regulating new models as they come out. But the incidents demonstrate the risks posed even while AI is being developed. It also raises thorny legal questions, because anti-hacking laws only punish intentional unauthorised access. If the consequences had been more costly, who would have been liable?

Reaping what was sown



Photograph: DPA

On Friday the UN's Food and Agriculture Organisation releases its monthly index of food prices around the world. So far, they have withstood this year's disruptions. But a shock is coming.

Production costs take up to six months to show on supermarket shelves; Máximo Torero, the FAO's chief economist, expects prices to start climbing sharply by the end of 2026.

The closure of the [Strait of Hormuz](#) has impacted the whole agricultural supply chain: from the chemicals needed for fertiliser to the crude needed to process, package and transport food. Less wheat and maize was planted globally this year as a result. Even in America, which can produce much of its own fuel and fertiliser, one industry group argues that farmers of nine major crops could face net losses of more than \$30bn in 2027 without federal help. Meanwhile, an unusually strong El Niño weather pattern is shifting rainfall: [India's monsoon](#) is erratic, threatening its rice crop, while Australia expects its winter crop to shrink by 21%.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which deadly sin is said to come before a fall?

Thursday: What suffix is used in taxonomy to refer to feet?

There are people who make things happen, people who watch things happen and people who wonder what happened.

Jim Lovell